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Influence of M-Learning Apps to Improve Eight graders Speaking skills in an Ecuadorian Public High School of the Coast

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Dedication

For my beloved family, for their unconditional support and love.

Andrea Alexandra

Acknowledgment

Today I can see another goal accomplished so that I dedicate this work to God, my parents, and my sister that had always been there to support me with their words, patience, advice, and love. Thanks to those values, I have obtained my master's degree to become a better teacher.

I also dedicate this thesis to my thesis' advisor Mgtr. Eva Ulehlova, whose help and guidelines have been fundamental when developing this work.

Andrea Alexandra

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Abstract

M-learning and MALL are creating new learning opportunities in the EFL teaching field with the implementation of smartphones that bring concrete and notable results in the classroom. For this reason, this research investigated the Influence of M-Learning Apps to Improve Eight graders Speaking skills in an Ecuadorian Public High School of the Coast students'. This research work was conducted in a public high school in Santo Domingo-Ecuador; the sample included 60 students from eighth grade. The research method used was quasi-experimental, and the data was obtained from qualitative and quantitative information.

This data was gathered from a pre-test, a post-test, and sample observations that helped measure students' speaking performance. Additionally, an observation sheet was used during the development of the experiment to monitor students' progress. Moreover, a survey was applied to find out students' perceptions about the use of these three apps. As a result of this study, the participants considerably improved their speaking skills. The most effective app was Duolingo because of its ability to increase students' motivational and confidence levels needed to improve their English spoken skills.

***Keywords*:** Mobile Apps, Duolingo, Tik Tok, Pod-cast, Oral Skills.

Resumen

El aprendizaje mobil (m-learning) y MALL (mobile assisted language learning) están creando nuevas oportunidades en el campo de la enseñanza del EFL con la implementación de teléfonos inteligentes que traen resultados concretos y notables en la clase. Por esa razón, este trabajo investigo tuvo como fin investigar La influencia de de aplicaciones mobiles para mejorar la destreza oral en estudiantes de Octavo año de colegios fiscales en la costa Ecuatoriana. Fue realizado en un colegio público de la cuidad de Santo Domingo-Ecuador; la muestra que se uso fue de 60 estudiantes del octavo año. El método investigativo fue Cuasiexperimental, los datos obtenidos incluían datos cualitativos y cuantitativos.

Por otra parte, la información obtenida del pre-, post-evaluación, y muestras de observacion ayudo a medir el desempeño de cada estudiante al hablar. Adicionalmente, se empleó una hoja de observación durante el desarrollo del experimento para medir el progreso de los estudiantes. También se aplicó una encuesta para determinar las percepciones que tienen los estudiantes cuando se refiere al uso de las tres aplicaciones. Como resultado de la investigación, se puede observar que los participantes incrementaron y mejoraron sus habilidades orales. La aplicación más efectiva en relación a las otras dos fue Duolingo debido a que esta app incrementa los niveles de motivación y confianza al momento de mostrar sus destrezas al hablar Inglés.

***Palabras claves*:** Aplicaciones Móviles, Tik Tok, Duolingo, Pod-cast, Destrezas orales.

Introduction

This project examines the fundamental role that innovative educative tools, namely communication technologies (ICTs) and mobile-assisted language learning (MALL), currently plays in English language teaching when introducing mobile learning (m-learning) into Ecuadorian high schools as a means to improve students' speaking skills. Incorporating new approaches and technologies will accomplish the quality required in accordance with the new reality as ICTs and MALL are employed to provide instruction toward relevant communication skills to students (Abunowara, 2016).

Technological advances are creating new learning opportunities, changing traditional learning methods. Similarly, teachers and students' roles are also being redefined. Research has shown that Ecuador is the last country out of nineteen in all Latin America and ranks 93rd in the world to master the four Basic English skills (Education First, 2020). Therefore, Ecuadorian teaching methods and learning experiences must be dynamic, efficient and inventive. Teachers must take advantage of new technologies that prepare students according to their learning styles nowadays and for the global future demands (Sun, 2017).

Since mobile technology for education has been greatly improved, its use is complementary to face-to-face instruction. With teachers as facilitators, in addition to textbooks and didactic materials, learning with mobile technology becomes more interesting, meaningful, and productive. Smartphones have computing characteristics that allow users to communicate with other students, create documents, read data files, and access the internet (Hussin et al., 2012). Likewise, Haerazi (2020), Sun et al., (2017), and Al-Mohammadi (2014) conclude that the use of m-learning increases English speaking skills significantly.

Although research on using specific mobile apps to improve English language speaking remains scant, some in-depth studies have been carried out to explore if the use of apps can considerably increase oral proficiency. The next studies support mobile applications that were implemented in this research project. Samad et al. (2017) examined

how the use of podcasts in elementary schools upgraded speaking skills in fluency and pronunciation. Students were engaged in and out of the classroom by listening to a variety of audio files, repeating while reading, and performing speaking tasks designed so that high school students sharpen their oral skills by completing storytelling tasks through the Tik Tok app (Zaitun et al. 2021). As a result, students articulated their oral expression in a very fluent and confident manner. Hafifah (2021) confirmed Duolingo's usefulness in broadening high schoolers' speaking skills. At the same time, student engagement was high because Duolingo made learners play a multitude of reinforcement activities. Hamzaoğlu and Koçoğlu (2016) worked on a study examining how high schoolers improve their speaking skills by listening, repeating, and then creating podcasts. Students remarkably enhanced pronunciation and vocabulary during the whole study.

This thesis aimed at showing how to improve Ecuadorian eighth-grade students' speaking skills by ensuring the implementation of mobile devices, websites, apps, and content creation tools. Using the communicative language teaching (CLT) approach and mobile learning (m-learning), students can progress their communicative competence using quick access, comprehensible input, individual and cooperative interaction, obtain immediate feedback whenever they have doubts or commit mistakes, and encompass student-centered learning with the teacher in a facilitator role. The main research questions were: How can m-learning and its apps be used to increase students' speaking skills such as pronunciation, fluency, and accuracy? Which Apps are considered the most effective ones for improving speaking skills? What are students' perceptions on the use of Duolingo, Tik Tok, and Podcast apps to strengthen oral skills?

This study is important since it will contribute to Ecuadorian public high school students from the coast region, enhancing their English output through speaking with the use of innovative techniques such as the use of Mobiles Apps inside and outside their classrooms. Thus, this study focus on providing students with confidence, motivation at the moment of fostering a foreign language, equal the opportunities for public high schools

students to develop their English speaking output performance above average in comparison to private schools students.

The first chapter refers to the literature review used for this research explaining reasons for implementing ICT's in schools, Advantages, and Disadvantages of ICT's, Implications for improving speaking skills, Communicative Language Teaching and ICTs, Mobile-Assisted Language Learning, and previous studies related to the use of ICTs, and mobile apps to improve English speaking skills.

The second chapter of the thesis explains how Duolingo, Tik Tok, and Pod-cast were used to help students develop their English oral skills, creating different social media material; videos, audios that demonstrate knowledge on their speaking skills using some indicators and their applications. These indicators contain four domains that focus on vocabulary, pronunciation, grammar, and fluency. Each domain has three criteria that will allow teachers to confirm whether the use of M-apps is beneficial to develop the desired skill.

For the next chapter, the data obtained allowed a comparison of results from each app regarding the indicators tested; pronunciation, vocabulary, grammar, and fluency to produce a correct English oral output. In addition, these indicators will allowed for the researcher to answer the three research questions stated at the beginning of this thesis.

Finally, it is relevant to clarify that this study was limited due to the current pandemic situation where class observations were not reliable as been in a typical classroom since all the work has been done through Zoom meetings. The working sample should have been divided into smaller groups.

Currently, very little evidence exists concerning training teachers in m-learning use. Various studies have been published that describe the use of Communications Technologies (ICTs) towards the study of English; nevertheless, limited studies have been conducted or published describing the influence of Mobile Apps like Tik Tok, Duolingo, and Pod-Cast as Mobile Apps used to improve English speaking skills.

It is suggested for further studies that teachers must look for new methodological and innovative teaching techniques to promote students' motivation when applying any Mobile App inside and outside the classroom. For example, researchers should identify which mobile app is most beneficial to develop each speaking skill or identify which app will accomplish grammar and fluency proficiency by working simultaneously with more interactive speaking activities. Additionally, to have better control over the students' performance, it will be helpful to divide the participants into smaller groups of 30, instead of 60.

Chapter one

Literature review

ICTs have transformed education considerably by revolutionizing processes and systems to the point that ministries of education worldwide have integrated ICTs in their instructional organizations, from kindergarten right up to university level. (Hwa, 2018; Khan & Kuddus, 2020; Topper & Lancaster, 2013). Modern language teaching has been influenced by ICT; becoming a fundamental condition in current education, ICT took digital literacy and turned out to be one of the essential lifelong learning skills that students must know besides literacy and numeracy (Hafifah, 2020). Hence, ICT use was integrated as a priority facilitator tool in the development of the Ecuadorian education curriculum (IBEC, 2017).

To begin with, ICT comprises a broad scope of media technology from hardware such as computers, laptops, tablets, smartphones, digital audio and visual equipment, and software applications to information systems such as Internet and cloud media platforms (Shah & Empungan (2015). In the same way, Asabere and Enguah (2012) defined ICT as an instructional atmosphere with the physical structure and digital information services in all forms, including voice, text, graphics, and video. Then, Kline and Stokes (2017) expressed ICT as a term used to cover a broad category of technology wherein user devices, programs, and networks interact and process data in the digital world. These new technologies change and impact society and its establishments constantly. Although the introduction of technology does not cause significant changes in society, how people interpret and interact with the technology does (as cited in Muhlbauer & Harry, 2017).

1.1 Reasons for implementing ICTs in schools

The use of ICTs in the English foreign language (EFL) classrooms began during the 1950s. Still, it did not significantly impact education because technology use was not a current practice. Eventually, with the development of the first generation of home computers in the 1980s, computer technology in EFL classrooms was increased (Alsied & Pathan 2013). This new technology and its approaches were not easily familiarized during

this time gap due to the fact teachers preferred the use of blackboards and chalk over technology (Warschauer & Meskill, 2000, as cited in Izadpanah & Alavi, 2016). Since the 1990s, ICTs have been integrated into all English teaching and learning stages (Ekinci & SireKaya, 2018; Jayanthi & Kumar, 2016).

Hwa (2018) states, “Education has evolved from the use of traditional methods of instruction to the use of ICTs for instruction” (p. 259). Since that time, ICTs have been reorganizing English teaching methodology; schools are emphasizing obtaining equipment and training for teachers (Izadpanah & Alavi, 2016; Charpentier Jiménez, 2014). Furthermore, because this technology makes learning easy and effective, and learner-centered, ICTs are now implemented to create an up-to-date authentic learning environment in countries where English is taught as a foreign language (Anan & Susanto, 2018; Khan & Kuddus, 2020).

ICTs’ introduction is a natural and appropriate process for young EFL learners. Children remember pictures more and are very enthusiastic on mobile devices. Moreover, ICT makes the learning environment fun with the use of sound, video, and animation by affecting students’ emotions. In the same way, by establishing more student collaboration in the class, teachers provide a productive learning environment and offer technology-based cognitive activities instruction (Shkvyr et al., 2020).

Weert & Tatnall (2005) find that the use of ICTs contributes to language teaching by responding to intellectual challenges that strengthen real-life learning, solve problems, and raise confidence in the students. Separating from ambiguous and old-fashioned learning methods, ICTs allow the development of language skills with precision, improving students’ communication in the classroom (Haerazi, 2020). Furthermore, through ICTs, students gain confidence and speak more fluently by acquiring the language quickly and comprehensibly. Consequently, teachers are able to perform effectively and innovatively, at the same time being continually updated in students’ learning processes in their daily classwork (Al-Mohammadi, 2014).

Moreover, 21st-century skills education mandates students to acquire and seek their own knowledge, including collaboration, communication, analytic reasoning, creativity, problem-solving, and teamwork (Dillon, 2017). To support this growth of 21st-century skills, the change in pedagogy towards dynamic problem-based and inquiry-based learning raises teachers' awareness (Lu, Bridges, & Hmelo-Silver, 2014, as cited in Spector et al., 2016). Conversely, educational institutions need to invest in using ICT suited for problem-solving skills, personalized learning, and meaningful diagnostic purposes so education can be modernized and innovated. This maintained learning atmosphere could contribute to life-long learning (Shkvyr et al., 2020; Spector et al., 2016). Therefore, ICT remains essential in the progress of higher-order skills as 21st-century skills in areas such as work and the professional regions and world citizenship and sustainable development (González-Salamanca et al., 2020).

Coincidentally, digital competence, a popular term in schools and lesson plans, signifies a practical and clever use of the process of creating, processing, and sharing data using ICTs (Shkvyr et al., 2020). The concepts of ICTs interconnect with the principles of digital competence, meaning the latter selects the most beneficial ICT tools to have meaningful online participation in school, society, and the world. Digital competence is expected to transform due to changes in culture and technology. That is why teachers and schools need to make an effort to constantly identify and update this set of technological skills into classroom practice, assessment tests, and the educational curriculum (Al Khateeb, 2017).

1.1.1 Advantages of ICTs

ICT use strengthens student motivation and engagement, essential to student academic success (Cagiltay, 2007; Sabiri, 2020; Sundqvist et al., 2021). Also, teachers support students' motivation using multimedia content. Apart from motivation, prior knowledge is better activated, and class participation is increased when software and apps are put into practice (Sundqvist et al., 2021). Moreover, ICT tools offer an array of multimedia academic content that employs authentic language models (Alsied & Pathan

2013). Over the years, this collection of authentic texts written by native speakers and their cultures has been classified and included in the course syllabus, helping learners with scaffolding and follow-up tasks for deepening understanding (Sabiri, 2020).

ICT shifts the learning environment from teacher-centered to learner-centered (Alsied & Pathan 2013; Castro-Sanchez & Aleman 2011; Nomass, 2013; Watson et al., 2011) because students use the language in natural settings (Alsied & Pathan 2013), play language objective games, and become active participants (Watson et al., 2011). As a result, this interactive learning environment keeps students studying on their own in a natural and habitual way because they use their mobile devices and computers in day-to-day life (Smythe & Neufeld, 2010).

ICT is a library of knowledge for students that readily adapts to their academic needs (Sabiri, 2020). By having access to new information and getting constructive feedback immediately, students achieve academic success (Pourhosein & Zabuhniaemaran 2015; Oxkert, 2018). In addition, providing constant feedback sharpens language communication skills (Sabiri, 2020).

The computer with web-based applications and social networks can be helpful for improving and practicing speaking and pronunciation with native speakers in authentic and challenging situations (Alsied & Pathan 2013). In addition, most teachers use ICT tools for teaching oral skills (Yang & Huang, 2008), especially with several explicit phonetic EFL activities (Saito & Plonsky, 2019). Thus, learning web-based applications makes students acquire speaking skills efficiently and quickly (Nomass, 2013).

Technology supports formative feedback as a way of scaffolding and differentiating instruction. (Spector et al., 2016). Web-based and app activities ensure proper testing of students' language skills by allowing teachers to design their personalized and learner-based tests (Alsied & Pathan 2013). For instance, a computer-assisted adaptive learning tool provides an individualized learning experience by utilizing sophisticated data-driven training which adjusts according to feedback, anticipating contents and lessons. Thus, ICTs

provide tailored support to students along their unique learning journey (Spector et al., 2016).

1.1.2 Disadvantages of ICTs

When integrating ICT into learning, teachers experience external and internal difficulties in class development. External problems include lack of time to cover the syllabus, teaching resources, large classes, limited technology devices and Internet, and lack of pedagogical and technical assistance. Internal difficulties lie in teachers' attitudes, such as a diffident manner and insufficient knowledge of technology use (Sabiri, 2020).

Moreover, negative beliefs about instructional technology wield significant influence on EFL teachers; they lack knowledge and interest in making classes with ICTs work (Pourhosein & Zabuhniaemaran, 2015). As a result, most teachers do not employ these tech gadgets or do not use them correctly (Kurt & Bensen, 2017).

Some teachers seem to be using ICT in their classes, but they use it 80% of that time for social communication and personal use and only 10% for learning activities (Prasojo et al., 2018). Another major drawback of teachers' negative beliefs is not worrying about upgrading their technical skills to keep pace with technology growth and mobile devices. When not improving their ICT proficiency, teachers become digitally handicapped and start losing students' trust and respect (Muñoz-Luna & Taillefer 2018).

1.2 Implications for improving speaking skills

Speaking is the interactive skill to express constructed meaning and establish communication that includes producing and processing information (Dewi et al., 2016; Harmenr, 2001). Speaking skills also involve finding correct words, using grammar, using rhythm, and following stress and intonation patterns (Turkben, 2019). Consequently, speaking skills are difficult skills to acquire for EFL learners since they need to speak fluently and accurately to be understood (Namaziandost & Ahmadi, 2019; Rao, 2019).

That being the case, oral skills are the essential skills from the four basic English language skills because becoming an effective communicator is possible because verbal skills are acquired (Dewi et al., 2016; Rao, 2019). Ultimately, communicating effectively is

the most significant of all skills to deal effectively with the challenges of everyday life (Sreena & Ilankumaran, 2018). By these means, good oral communication skills have long-term effects such as enhancing career and getting better employment opportunities (Rao, 2019).

Improving speaking skills responds to several fundamental elements throughout the learning process. First, instructors should determine the kind of spoken language function they will teach. Teachers should be concerned about teaching the language and teach a language that fosters relationships with students. EFL language teaching has concentrated on the transactional function of language. That is to say, structures that get something done in speaking lessons.

On the other hand, interactional language has been diminishing in importance. Interactional language is produced for social purposes, being the language of making friends and maintaining relationships (Higareda et al., 2009). Furthermore, interactional language is listener-oriented and transactional language is message-oriented (Brown & Yule, 1983). Therefore, differentiating these two functions of spoken language when planning speaking activities helps learners acquire key language for accomplishing speaking activities (Higareda et al., 2009).

Second, interactivity plays a significant role in the EFL process because teacher-learner or learner-learner collaboration enhances verbal language development (Saeed et al., 2016) and raises opportunities for learners to ask questions, reach conclusions, and socialize according to their interests (Gavrilovici & Kovacevic, 2018). When teachers create true interactional speaking activities, students communicate among themselves, but they also have the target to help each other figure out language problems. That is to say, understanding how the language works facilitates oral communication rather than just practicing the language (Higareda et al., 2009). A good strategy aiming at learners' interactivity and cooperation implements storytelling techniques. Storytelling enhances comprehension, fluency, vocabulary, grammar, and pronunciation (Sharma, 2018).

Third, devising quick ways to integrate pronunciation into speaking classes should be done along with all instruction (Levis & Grant, 2003). Through hard consonant and vowel pronunciation activities, teachers must help EFL learners perceive the differences between English and their mother tongue. In addition, there should be specific speaking lessons where EFL students listen and learn sounds that do not exist in students' first language (Albiladi, 2019). For this purpose, phonology instruction results in better segmental and suprasegmental levels. Segmental levels comprise consonants and vowels. Suprasegmental levels consist of stress, rhythm, and intonation (Brown, 2001; Derwing, 2008; Kenworthy, 1987; Pennington, 1996).

Observing earlier research shows that improving pronunciation and speaking skills is impossible if teachers do not improve listening skills first (Newton, 2020). This is due to the fact that listening skills impact speaking skills (Amalia, 2017). Therefore, listening and pronunciation are interconnected skills and cannot be detached. By implementing lessons that establish the connection between these two skills, EFL teachers can help learners improve their pronunciation skills. Similarly, teaching stress patterns aids students in learning correct pronunciation and language's natural rhythm. Another main difficulty with EFL students concerning pronunciation is that learners are not exposed to native speaker sources. When students do not listen to these sources, comprehension and intelligible pronunciation problems appear. Therefore, EFL teachers must employ effective mobile apps to supply this pressing need (Albiladi, 2019).

Afterward, all activities must aim to use the language as a communication system and not as a school subject (Haberl, 2018). Students should have a purpose in all speaking activities; the more realistic the need for communication, the most effective the speaking tasks will be. Teachers should avoid asking students to repeat, and they must give choices and have students practice long sentences. New oral activities and formats should be introduced, such as talking to different students, to the whole class, to small groups, differentiating stronger or weaker students and their activities, and speaking using mobile devices (To'xtasinovna, 2019). Gradually, EFL students acquire communicative

competence to use the language to communicate effectively, focusing on meaning rather than form (Gavrilovici & Kovacevic, 2018).

Next, fluency, one of the key components of speaking skills, is an oral proficiency that controls how speaking is expressed in an effortless way (Duran-Karaoz & Tavakoli, 2020). In addition, fluency must be seen as a confident use of spoken language, including silences, pronunciation, rhythm or stress, adjustments, and mistakes (Haberl, 2018). Imitation and repetition of oral tasks aid students in acquiring speed, grammar, and vocabulary structures (Nation, 1989). The focal point of the function of speaking fluency development is processing meaning. For students to speak fluently, activities must be designed to help learners to convey their messages. Students need to be familiar with the content or target vocabulary and grammar structures, and teachers should push students to perform at a faster speed. Grammar, or accuracy, plays a key role in developing fluency when grammar and fluency are merged (Yang, 2013). At the same time, speaking fluency development will improve grammar accuracy (Nation, 1997).

Further, grammar and vocabulary help speaking competence by providing the structure students require to convey their messages accurately. This proper use of language structures is significant for students' oral proficiency because grammar serves a central role in learning those language organizations (Wang, 2014). Teaching grammar explicitly helps with spoken language acquisition because when students pay attention to target structures, they will probably acquire and use them (Bahrani & Soltani, 2012). In other words, selective grammar teaching develops students' spoken language by asking learners to use target grammar with communicative tasks. (Kreutner, 2015). Instructors develop communicative competence in speaking by combining language input that mixes vocabulary and grammar and communicative output by asking learners to perform authentic tasks and get their messages across (Bahrani & Soltani, 2012). Project-based learning tasks are good examples of how students incorporate explicit grammar instruction and communicative activities, so learners explore the relation between meaning and form (Kreutner, 2015).

A significant development in improving speaking is the use of mobile learning (m-learning) or Mobile Assisted Language Learning (MALL) (Shamsi et al., 2018). Since speaking time in class is limited, students need ample time to practice target vocabulary and structures. This is achieved by the efficient use of mobile apps or MobApps (Shamsi et al., 2018). In addition, since many EFL students feel anxious when they must participate in speaking activities (Horwitz et al., 1986), m-learning decreases anxiety by changing students' attitudes and by providing extra content, additional time, and confidence when using mobile devices (Shamsi et al., 2018). To this end, there are many pronunciation apps that help learners' pronunciation, grammar, and fluency.

A good example is the Macmillan Education pronunciation app. This application includes an interactive phonemic chart where students tap to hear a sound and see words with that sound. Next, learners can look up, listen, and record words in the wordlist. Then, students can test with the pronunciation quizzes, use the phonemic typewriter, and learn with top tics and videos (Manigandan et al., 2017).

1.3 Communicate Language Teaching and ICTs

Providing plenty of suitable opportunities to make real communication and use the target vocabulary is the principle of Communicative Language Teaching (CLT). It rules all contemporary language teaching methods (Buckingham & Alpaslan, 2017; Zewdu & Molla, 2020). Modern CLT comprehensibly merges high standard educational content with adaptable communicating multimedia. This learning method acts as either a teaching tool with academic courses or a self-study solution (Akintunde & Angulu, 2015).

In addition, learners develop a great variety of speaking skills through several responsive activities (Akintunde & Angulu, 2015). The CLT approach favors teachers because it avoids concentrating on grammar and vocabulary and stresses spoken language and meaning. The goal is completing oral communicative tasks rather than ensuring language accuracy (Dewi et al., 2016). For instance, games give intense and passionate involvement in verbal communication, giving students enjoyment and pleasure in learning (Dewi et al., 2016; Mahmoud & Tanni, 2014).

On account of CLT, instructional methodology for facilitating spoken communication and reasoning skills in elementary schools has been employed based on didactic experience and teacher-student interaction. This method primarily aims to find the target information, use problem-solving skills, and evaluate information flow by using ICT and MobApps. To be specific, the following steps should be employed: first, teaching students to find essential information for solving a common school life problem that needs to be addressed. Second, acquiring the ability to compare, analyze, and summarize the primary details using apps. And third, teaching students to make personal or collaborative decisions or arguments; fourth, making sure students' decisions are reasonable and informed. Finally, independent work using oral communication is presented in pairs or groups. (Shkvyr et al, 2020).

When teaching communicative language-speaking activities, students achieve exponential growth with an autonomy support learning environment, namely instructors acknowledging learners' perspectives and opinions and presenting different web-based language choices. By reducing demands and academic pressure, teachers encourage students' independence when using the information in their own way. That learning environment increases students' language growth mindset, proficiency, oral communication, and academic achievement (Zarrinabadi et al., 2021).

As previously stated, by designing communicative and collaborative tasks that use technology and promote social interaction, teachers encourage spoken language development to meet learners' needs (Garcia-Esteban & Tejedor-Martinez, 2014). For instance, when taking advantage of pictures, audio, and touch capabilities, interactive whiteboards (IWBs) such as SmartBoard, allow instructors to engage in interactive teaching. In addition, IWBs support the learning process in different modern styles, making IWBs the CLT tool for excellence. A more pointed example is, using CLT activities with interactive whiteboards; instructors teach with visuals and audio and use the kinesthetic approach (Aldhafiri, 2020). Furthermore, being mainly visible to the class, students can do

listening comprehension and drag items, manipulate their answers or pictures, interact, check their answers, and assign their own activity marks easily in the IWB.

Afterward, teachers can select some students to explain their answers or check vocabulary words, and, at the same time, students can follow in their smartphones or tablets (Shkvyr et al., 2020).

As E-learning (online learning) was the predecessor of mobile learning, Computer-Assisted Language Learning (CALL) was the forerunner of Mobile-Assisted Language Learning (MALL). Although these two learning models still co-exist, the difference lies in that while CALL is stationary in the classroom, MALL is portable on a global scale (Almarshadi et al., 2019). MALL is the learning model that helps students acquire language through Mobapps (Haerazi et al., 2020). MALL is an emerging advanced ICT that opens up learner-centered opportunities through reachable and flexible uses. Above all, MALL is a trend in the EFL world. (Ahn & Lee, 2016; Castaneda & Cho, 2016; Haerazi et al., 2020). This approach obtains impressive results in diverse EFL areas, such as improving listening to comprehension and speaking skills (Hwang et al., 2016), remembering key vocabulary (Hwang & Chen, 2013), and acquiring reading fluency (Lan et al., 2007).

First, assisting teachers is a benefit of using MALL by designing interactive digital content that provides easy access to language learning anywhere or anytime (Cochrane & Bateman, 2010; Shamsi et al., 2018). In essence, mobile phones offer characteristics such as texting, camera, audio, video, and google searching that give teachers abilities to personalize their classroom materials and interact with their pupils. In turn, it demands teachers to apply critical thinking, including analyzing arguments, making inferences, and problem-solving skills (Haerazi et al., 2020). Smartphones demonstrate abilities to take education to a level never seen before. Language learning theories such as constructivism, collaborative approach, CLT, and learner-centered approach reflect this effective device. Even though the general population thinks smartphones per se make students learn, authentic input and relevant content, sound foundations of CLT, turn out to be the decisive

factor. A teacher who takes control of this learning process and enables communicative strategies makes it all possible (Walsh, 2019).

Second, learner autonomy is one of the distinctive characteristics that MALL devices provide learners because MALL develops students' skills to learn languages effortlessly (Ahn & Lee, 2016; Shamsi et al., 2018). It supplies students with an extensive range of practicing listening and speaking. For example, social networking sites (SNSs) aid EFL learners to achieve great competence through social interaction (Ahn & Lee, 2016). SNSs increase young students' speaking skills in three areas: accuracy, fluency, and Pronunciation (Khan & Kuddus, 2020). In this regard, Thornbury (2005) defines accuracy as the correct use of grammatical structures. Hughes (2002) states that fluency is the ability of students to communicate quickly without interruptions. Finally, pronunciation is the key factor in expressing the right sounds and stressing the correct syllables intelligibly (Cavus, 2016). To such a degree, SNSs enhance students' speaking skills when used appropriately. Likewise, social media affords time and shortens the distance, so a relaxing learning environment motivates students to practice their speaking skills openly and anxiety-free (Namaziandost & Nasri, 2018).

Third, creating an unconstrained and asynchronous learning environment, MALL virtually provides infinite input and abundant multimode feedback (Pennington & Rogerson-Revell, 2019). Immediate feedback after speaking activities is key to training pronunciation and intelligibility (Baker & Burri, 2016). For example, Nguyen et al. (2018) developed a mobile translation app named Eztranslate, which simulates how people learn their native language by exposing students to listening and imitating. Eztranslate performs four roles: speech translation, speech shadowing, history and map, and homework submission. In the first role, students play spoken phrases, and sentences are translated so learners with limited vocabulary can listen immediately. Speech shadowing helps repeat the exact translated words and sentences many times by absorbing grammar structures and vocabulary in a fluent way. Next, using a pedometer, 116 first-year university students in two teams were asked to describe familiar places as follow-up tasks after class instruction.

Finally, using a real-time server, the team evaluated saved responses and checked homework. Students outperformed in their activities and, by using repetition, pronunciation scores rose. The team drew attention to the assumption that designing effective and authentic lessons using m-learning requires teachers to plan effective pedagogical teaching with precise guidance through all the tasks.

Generally speaking, MALL is implemented in most EFL classrooms because of low speaking proficiency. As a result, EFL teachers keep teaching grammar rules and vocabulary and adopt passive learning styles. Because of this, students focus on accuracy and grammar. As discussed before, speaking skills include accuracy, fluency, and complexity, but EFL students do not have practice in fluency and complexity. MALL sharpens oral skills by supplementing practice in these two skills (Sun et al., 2017).

With this in mind, bringing significant improvements to conversation skills, mobile speaking applications with automatic speech recognition (ASR) corrects Pronunciation (Ahn & Lee, 2016). These apps show real promise for EFL students' speaking skills because students reduce stress when using automatic speech recognition or SNS apps to communicate compared to face-to-face conversations (Ahn & Lee, 2016; Mostafavi & Vahdany, 2016). From another angle, mobile game-based learning websites and apps assist students' progress of speaking skills by having them talk to their mobile devices (Hwang et al., 2016). Indeed, human mobile device interaction with SNS leads to more efficient and genuine EFL learning (Sun et al., 2017).

While audio recordings have been popular EFL tools, dedicated online oral journals, voice blogs, and podcasts are suitable tools to supply students with detailed feedback on their pronunciation. In the same way, these apps are vehicles for outside the class practice or complementing limited chances for oral practice in the classroom. For instance, free online websites, such as Vocaroo.com, aid teachers in designing asynchronous lessons where students discuss topics or answer questions in an oral journal. Through a time period action plan, teachers can have learners identify pronunciation and vocabulary difficulties. After practice with other online tools and materials, students submit their links

for correction using emails. Then teachers correct mistakes and resend their responses with oral notes (Baker & Burri, 2016; Buckingham & Alpaslan, 2017).

1.4 Mobile-Assisted Language Learning

Mobile learning, also known as M-learning, is the interaction among learners and mobile devices allowing students to access online information in multiple contexts anywhere and anytime (Akkara, et al., 2020; Crompton, 2013; Ozdamli & Cavus 2011; Traxler, 2007). This interaction makes the art of learning a language mobile in terms of place and time (Almarshadi et al., 2019; Ghallab, 2020). Presently, M-learning puts learners at the heart of education by supporting adaptability, user-friendliness, and convenience (Crompton, 2013). The value of M-learning is obvious and compulsory. Thereby it is implemented by several teachers and researchers (Haerazi et al., 2020; Hussin et al., 2012).

MobApps have effected extensive changes to EFL teaching and learning, such as teachers' and students' reasoning, didactic designs, and teachers' and students' roles in practice and testing the target language (Haerazi et al., 2020). The far-reaching change that M-learning aims to provide is bringing students into an educational environment that makes learning engaging, handy, stimulating, and meaningful (Ghallab, 2020). This kind of learning is intended to be achieved in a time frame and measured by quick assessment. (Hussin et al., 2012). Due to all these characteristics and the fact that mobile devices access videos, websites, podcasts, e-books, and social media, makes mobile devices have an infinite supply of oral skills for students and are ideal for improving speaking skills. Since learners can record themselves and listen to their pronunciation, mobile devices have become a self-improvement tool (Ghallab, 2020).

1.4.1 Advantages of Mobile Learning

M-learning is characterized by its multimedia capabilities. Students are able to record their spoken answers to questions and compare it to native speakers. Then, they can listen and correct pronunciation, think of new answers and record better responses. Since video is becoming mainstream in social media, recording and making videos are

good ways of learning English. Students enjoy creating and editing videos and turning them into podcasts or YouTube videos and, at the same time, practicing their language objectives. This becomes another benefit making most lessons hands-on activities (Ghallab, 2020) and enjoyable by recording videos and podcasts (Mehta, 2012).

Web access allows learners to find any information at the tip of their fingers. Different media can be displayed on their phones, helping students find the best ways of having comprehensible input. Having access to translators and online dictionaries aids learners to become independent students by exploring to collect information and personalizing it (Ghallab, 2020). Moreover, online learning activities are provided outside the class at any convenient time, maximizing virtual and classroom interaction (Mehta, 2012).

Social networking and instant feedback, as discussed before, are key elements in upgrading speaking skills because of the way students can exchange several responses and ideas by engaging in posts and surveys. This is more effective when pupils share their responses on Facebook or similar social media, demonstrating they perform better by giving quick spoken responses. In addition, having instant feedback helps learners reflect on their learning progression and learning strategies (Ghallab, 2020).

Downloading books, videos, and activities is easy and handy. Besides bringing money expenses to a minimum, students can have their EFL lessons and materials on their phones so studying can be done at their convenience. Downloading educational games is another value when students play games adjusted to their level and weak areas (Mehta, 2012).

1.4.2 Disadvantages of Mobile Learning

M-learning technology is a double-edged sword if teachers do not devise a detailed plan when dealing with smartphones' stumbling blocks (Almarshadi et al., 2019). Among the most common drawbacks of M-learning are classroom distractions when students do not follow directions and start watching videos or websites that are not on the lesson or curriculum. Surfing social media and playing games are the most common infringements

during face-to-face or online classes. Then, cheating is next on the list. Students start using online dictionaries or passing test answers and photos using social media when taking quizzes or short assessments. These are serious offenses that teachers must deal with properly. Next, some students become so engaged with some MobApps, and they forget the most important community they have to interact with in the classroom and its peers. However, another hindrance is technical problems. Instructors need to constantly check computers, devices, networks, and equipment before and after instruction to ensure all is in optimal condition. They even need to be familiar with the MobApps are using so they can troubleshoot any malfunction or network failure (Ghallab, 2020). Finally, teachers have to deal with mobile phones shortcomings, such as limited display, small keyboard, limited battery life, limited memory, devices stolen or corrupted, and failure to connectivity issues (Mehta, 2012).

1.5 Mobile Learning in the EFL Classroom

Mobile devices have been evaluated as proper EFL classroom instruments by researchers, instructors, curriculum designers, and computer programmers (Ghallab, 2020). More specifically, speaking skills are considerably improved by implementing M-learning (Almarshadi et al., 2019; Lys, 2013). Numerous M-learning MobApps aid students in picking up speaking skills such as video conference apps, online video libraries, mobile app messages, and podcasts (Sreena & Ilankumaran, 2018). Likewise, cartoons and blogs engage learners interacting with language in and out of the classroom. For example, YouTube sparks students' curiosity and interest (Buzzetto-More, 2015) because it shows authentic videos that help practicing pronunciation and to listen to native speakers. As mentioned before, this kind of instruction is highly convenient because it rejects teacher-centered traditional methods (Khan & Kuddus, 2020).

In view of their importance to this project, the next apps would be instrumental in the improvement of students' speaking skills. The first one is Duolingo, an online language-learning platform and mobile application that provides English and foreign language learning in 27 different languages. Providing individualized training, Duolingo performs as a

private tutor through game-like tasks and ongoing assessment that caters all students' levels due to placement and progress adaptive tests. Through the different tabs in the main menu, students can choose a pool of activities that range from vocabulary, translation, grammar, games, and adaptive activities (Teske, 2017). The validity of this app has been researched in three functions, such as adaptive English placement test for EFL students (Ye, 2014), app efficacy for language learning (Vesselinov & Grego, 2012), and as a motivational language tool for EFL learners (Loewen et al., 2019). Although Duolingo falls short of teaching students in the authentic communicative output process, it creates a personalized learning experience for EFL students as a complementary learning device (Teske, 2017).

Tik Tok, launched in China in 2016, is now the high user engagement app, even exceeding Facebook as the most monthly used application (Scherr & Wang, 2021). The trendy Tik Tok app is a free social media network that allows students to watch, make, edit, and share 60 to 180 minutes videos, often to a popular song, in a user-friendly style. With an educational approach, this app makes it easier for students to get information and increase greater exposure in acquiring English in an unconventional and entertaining way (Zaitun et al., 2021). Teachers input the target language through videos, so students have a detailed model to follow. This is done by using the TikTok Video Challenge tool as a communicative language activity; on the one hand, the TikTok Video Challenge tool strengthens students' motivation and confidence to use spoken English, and on the other, this app is a path to practice speaking English without stress and fear (Aranego, 2020).

Turning now to podcasts, alternative media that helps students speak correctly and successfully. Podcasts are audio or digital video recordings that comprise television, the internet, and internet programs (Samad et al., 2017). Podcasts have been used to improve oral skills because they do not just accelerate listening skills but vocabulary, grammar, and pronunciation skills (Chan et al., 2011). As is the case with m-learning, podcasts allow teachers to enhance learning beyond the classroom. Podcasts are mainly used as shadowing techniques and authentic language exposure; they become vehicles for

speaking fluency and effective use of vocabulary in context. Moreover, podcasts act as public libraries delivering materials straight to mobile phones where students have extra explanations about main topics. Finally, by having different oral language samples, students become independent and confident when developing their own podcasts (Samad et al., 2017).

Finally, when planning speaking lessons using m-learning, the four-construct model must be considered. M-learning is focused on four constructs including the following: learning pedagogies, mobile devices, context, and social interactions. First, learning pedagogies are looking for the best ways learners acquire spoken language. These didactic strategies are influenced according to current social behavior and value. Secondly, students employ mobile devices and apps to enhance the target language and support individual learning styles. Thirdly, spontaneous or academic learning directed by others or oneself is context. Students can choose and assign their language objective tasks, having an active role in their learning. Lastly, social interactions are the oral language responses and goals that are expected in the lesson (Tiitinen, 2015).

1.6 Previous Studies

The following research studies are remarkable examples of how m-learning is used to improve speaking skills in EFL students. They aim to verify the benefits of using mobile devices with the sole purpose of sharpening and upgrading all oral skills with the assistance of educational MobApps combined with good teaching practices.

Sun et al. (2017) conducted this study to examine the use of mobile SNS to improve speaking skills. A pre and post-test were carried out to assess oral skills. Two first-grade EFL classes were enlisted, the first group made of 35 students as the control group and the second first-grade class as the experimental group comprising 37 students. The app chosen was Papa, deemed relatively safe. Students were asked to record their speaking responses in the app by answering questions such as what day is your best day? And why? among others. The experimental group was asked to take pictures and post them on their mobile devices. The study took a semester, and speaking skills were evaluated in

accuracy, fluency, and pronunciation. Although there was progress in both groups, the experimental one had higher gains in speaking fluency. It was concluded that mobile devices and SNSs produce four advantages: an encouraging environment, reduction of anxiety, situated learning, and user-friendly app.

Samad et al. (2017) researched if considerable progress was achieved on students' speaking skills using podcasts, especially in fluency and pronunciation. Thirty second grade students were chosen as samples for this pre-experimental research, where a pre-test and a post-test were given to the experimental group. Researchers collected data using oral tests in order to measure growth after students received several treatment sessions. During treatment sessions, researchers played the podcasts and asked students to listen, read the script, and imitate. Then, learners discussed their answers in groups. Teachers used their smartphones to record all responses, so evaluation was objective in fluency and pronunciation aspects. For data analysis, teachers examined students' scores based on speaking recordings. As a result, the findings revealed that after experiment, the students' performance in speaking skills improved significantly when it refers to fluency and pronunciation. Therefore, podcast media can be used as an alternative medium for teaching English, particularly rich oral output through their speaking skills, in EFL classes.

Ahn and Lee (2016) carried out a study using an ASR app named Speaking English 60 Junior used as a mechanism to increase English speaking skills. As a result, 302 middle-school students from five different schools increased their English-speaking proficiency using this app for two weeks. The method used for this study was a mixed-method. However, 54% of students expressed they found the app easy to use, 47% found it interesting, and 57% said the app was helpful when practicing English. The findings reveal that language learning in the context of EFL through the use of ASR and mobile phones had a favorable outcome since the majority of students had positive attitudes towards the use of the application.

Zaitun et al. (2021) did a study to determine the advancement of oral skills by carrying through storytelling activities about target language vocabulary using the Tik Tok

application. Thirty-six high school students were the subjects in this study. The method research used was qualitative with descriptors to reveal events and progress and classroom action research techniques. Researchers held one session for the pre-test and two sessions for the post-test. The results showed that students using Tik Tok increased speaking fluency, expressing their ideas confidently in the video format.

Hafifah (2021) study objective was to demonstrate Duolingo's effectiveness in improving speaking skills through a quasi-experimental method. The sample population was two groups of 20 tenth-grade high schoolers as the experimental and control groups. The experimental group obtained the treatment with the Duolingo App, and the control group was taught using traditional textbook instruction. For this study, the researcher used a pre-test and a post-test based on the school syllabus in all forty students. The try-out test consisted of 25 questions, 100 score/20 items, and calculations were done by computers. As a result, of the experiment, it was confirmed that the experimental group got the score of 13.75 points in contrast of the control group that was 8.75 points, with these results the researcher demonstrated that speaking skills were enhanced using Duolingo App from the data collection.

Hamzaoğlu and Koçoğlu (2016) undertook quasi-experimental research where students created their own podcasts to increase speaking skills in a Turkish EFL high school. The participants were 30 ninth graders distributed in two groups, 15 students per group. The participants were divided into a control and an experimental group. The control group followed the English textbook and its speaking activities, while the experimental group worked with the same English textbooks, but they created podcasts in the classroom for their speaking activities. Three kinds of data-collecting instruments were used for qualitative and quantitative purposes. First, a pre- and post-Foreign Language Class Anxiety Questionnaire was taken to measure the students' anxiety, another pre and post-proficiency test to evaluate the student's speaking performance, and finally, pre-and post-interviews about podcasting.

Results were excellent; the experimental group improved far more than those in the control group in the speaking performance test. Experimental group students increased their pronunciation and vocabulary, scoring 34 over the control group score of 27.33 in the post-tests. Moreover, students reported that they felt less anxious, more fluent, and could recycle learned structures with grammatically correct forms when creating their podcasts.

Chapter two

Method

2.1 Setting and Participants

The present study was carried out in an urban public high school in Santo Domingo. A total of 60 participants from this high school were selected to be part of this study, these participants were in eighth grade from parallel “B”. The students’ ages were between 12 and 13 years old. Their English levels were 0 to A1 because English is not considered the main subject in some Ecuadorian public schools. Also, there are insufficient or unqualified EFL teachers, and these subjects are left aside from the curriculum.

2.2 Procedure

This research contains information material extracted from different sources such as, scientific articles, books including analysis of multiple previous related studies conducted by different authors from all over the world.

This research was conducted through a Quasi-experimental method. The participants for this research were not chosen randomly. Instead, the sample had particular characteristics for the investigation to be developed due to the global pandemic. In addition, some parameters were required to be accomplished as part of the university's requirement. This study had three research questions that needed to be answered:

The first research question, *How can M-Apps improve learners’ achievement in speaking?* And the second question*: Which Apps are considered the most effective ones for improving speaking skills in pronunciation, fluency, grammar, and vocabulary?* The instrument used was an observation sheet for each class and app used. The criteria for the observation sheet were the same as the ones used in the pre and post-test. Also a rubric was applied to measure speaking performance.

To answer the third research question, What are the students’ perceptions on the use of Tick-tock, Duolingo, and Podcast Applications to improve students’ speaking skills? A questionnaire was used as part of an Instrument to collect the information at the end of the experiment, this questionnaire was sent through Google forms. This questionnaire was

ranged with a Likert Scale of agreement: strongly agree, agree, neutral, and disagree. The post-test had the same questions and the same evaluation as the pre-test.

For that reason, 15 sessions were designed emphasizing on improving these four specific aspects of oral interaction. The topics assessed during the intervention were Greetings, Comparatives, Family, Present Tense, and professions.

Before starting the intervention, each student was given a pre-test that measured their speaking skills, pronunciation, vocabulary, fluency, and grammar. The pre-test had three questions. Students had to read aloud a text, answer questions and describe a picture. In addition, for each class, an observation sheet was applied with parameters for vocabulary, pronunciation, grammar, and fluency was used to measured students' speaking performance.

During the development of these classes, students were observed by the teachers through an observation sheet with specific criteria for vocabulary use, pronunciation, fluency, and grammar with the help of a Likert scale where 1 was the lowest score, 3 was an average development, and 5 above-average performance. The same parameters were used for Tik Tok, Duolingo and Pod-cast.

After all, the information from the instruments was gathered, the results needed to be tabulated and organized carefully for its correct analysis to answer the research questions. The program to create the tables with the respective percentages of the results was Microsoft Excel.

Finally, based on the results obtained from the analysis regarding the Influence of M-Learning Apps to Improve Eight graders Speaking skills in an Ecuadorian Public High School of the Coast, a set of conclusions and recommendations were established.

Chapter three

Results and Discussion

Description, Analysis, and Interpretation of results

3.1 Analysis

The present study was carried out in an urban public high school in Santo Domingo. A total of 60 participants from this high school were selected to be part of this study, these participants were in eighth grade from parallel “B”. The students’ ages were between 12 and 13 years old. Their English levels were 0 to A1 because English is not considered the main subject in some Ecuadorian public schools. Also, there are insufficient or unqualified EFL teachers, and these subjects are left aside from the curriculum.

To be able to share the results of this study, this section will analyze the findings through the data gathered to answer the research questions: *How can M-Apps improve learners' achievement in speaking skills? Which Apps are considered the most effective for improving speaking skills in pronunciation, fluency, grammar, and vocabulary? What are the students’ perceptions of Tik-Tok, Duolingo, and Podcast Applications to enhance students' speaking skills?*

It is important to consider what Sengkey (2018) states about achieving a second language: learners need to master their language aptitude and social motivation. Language aptitude is taught and improved when students are taught pronunciation and speaking in class. This important part of teaching is sometimes left behind because of time and lack of planning. Social motivation is a result of the confidence students have when performing a collaborative task, when they receive an appraisal, and when they realize that they are achieving goals when communicating. On the other hand, Vural (2013) emphasizes that teachers should motivate students since they influence their students' rate and success of learning.

The following analysis includes the previous concepts as the guide to back up the findings.

3.1.1 How can the use of M Apps Improve Learner's Achievement in Speaking?

Table 10

Pronunciation results of pre and post-test

Criteria	PRE-TEST (%)	POST-TEST (%)
very hard to understand	90	5
satisfactory; however, some words have incorrect inflections	10	68.33
Accurate with correct inflections	0	26.77

Note: This table refers to the results of the pre and post-test regarding to pronunciation.

Based on the findings summarized in the table 1, 90% of the students conveyed a speech that was very hard to understand, 10% was satisfactorily understood. However, what needs to be highlighted is the fact that none of them were accurate when sharing their messages. According to the Ministry of Education has a Ministerial Agreement number MINEDUC-ME-2015-00069-A, the English levels of Ecuadorian students are classified according to CEFR – Common European Framework of Reference, 90% of them would be placed in a student-category of true beginner, matching the information given previously on the methodological part that stated that the students belong to a 0 level of English.

When analyzing the 10% of students that could transmit their ideas through a verbal output, this group of pupils presented incorrect pronunciation of words or inflections. Most of the mistakes were evidenced during the reading part. Some students still had problems articulating an oral answer when answering questions due to their lack of confidence in English speaking. In the third section, students had trouble using the correct pronunciation when structuring simple sentences that described each picture. It was evident that students did not have a clear notion of how sentences in simple past are structured and the correct use of verb forms in sentences.

Jahan (2011) explains that one of the most common problems that English students face is pronunciation since sound patterns of their mother tongue influence students' performance when enhancing a target language. This analysis clarifies that pronunciation becomes an area of possible improvement that was totally covered by applying the three apps, generating a great change when comparing the ciphers.

After the experiment, students took the post-test, which was similar to the first one, to establish the difference and infer if Mobile Apps help learners improve their achievement in pronunciation. According to table 1, the post-test results demonstrated that 68.33 % of students had improved their pronunciation reaching a satisfactory level, and 26.77 % had an outstanding performance due to an accurate pronunciation. These results have a synchronism with Manigandan's (2017) study that points out that students can increase their pronunciation skills through the use of mobile applications since they have an interactive phonemic where students, by tapping on the app, hear the sound of words and sentences.

However, despite these results, there is still 5% of students who did not improve and could become a group to be analyzed in further studies.

Table 11

Vocabulary results of pre and post-test

CRITERIA	PRE-TEST(%)	POST-TEST(%)
Vocabulary is very limited.	93.33	30.00
Vocabulary is moderate, sometimes speaker needs guidance.	6.67	58.33
Vocabulary is sufficient to be understood in a different context.	0	6.67
TOTAL	100	100

Note: This table refers to the results of the pre and post-test regarding to vocabulary.

Regarding table 2 that summarizes the use of vocabulary, the pre-test results showed that test levels were low. The 93.33% of students had limited vocabulary use and could not convey the message, making it hard to understand when they answered the questions about the reading (part 2) and when they were asked to describe pictures connected to the reading (part 3). 6.67% had a moderate vocabulary, and no students knew how to use the vocabulary accurately.

According to Manigandan's (2017), students must use target vocabulary in Communicative Language teaching (CLT) during classes and be in constant exposure to be able to convey a message successfully.

When applying the post-test, 58.33 % of the students' vocabulary was moderate when they read aloud the reading, answered questions, and described pictures because students were allowed to students to participate in responsive activities during the intervention, where they had to use the target language in a natural context, students had an input of words naturally to be able to replicate this in real communication (Buckingham & Alpaslan, 2017; Zewdu & Molla, 2020). Furthermore, mobile Apps help students link images with words; as a result, these words do not need to be translated to the native language to be understood, so learners with limited vocabulary are immediately fluent. In addition, technology supports formative feedback as a way of scaffolding and differentiating instruction. (Spector et al., 2016).

At the same time, 6.77% of students' had an accurately use of vocabulary since these students had two factors that helped their improvement significantly on vocabulary. First, they began the experiment with a better pronunciation than the rest of the class; second, their commitment to the use of Tik Tok, Duolingo, and Pod-cast for their improvement on speaking was evidenced on time spend using these apps in contrast to the rest of the class that only used the apps for 10 minutes a day while they used it for more than an hour. Additionally, these students began to post more than one Tik Tok video per day on social media and started to interact more than once with their different points of view to their classmate's Pod-cast.

Thirty percent of students still need more intervention because their vocabulary still is very limited. It can be observed that when students had to read the lecture on part 1 of the post-test, students had trouble reading nine out of ten sentences. When they had to answer the three questions of part 2, all these students did not answer them. It can be seen on their faces that they did not understand the question, which is why they could not answer. Finally, they were asked to describe pictures few students could connect images with words. Even though most of the words used in the reading, questions, and pictures were used during the whole experiment, practicing them more than once with Tik Tok, Duolingo, and Pod-cast.

Table 12

Fluency results of of pre and post-test

CRITERIA	PRE-TEST(%)	POST-TEST(%)
The speaker has many hesitations.	96.66	8.33
The speaker hesitates several times, needing time to think about using some words a bit.	3.33	51.66
The speaker speaks confidently, and the conversation flows smoothly.	0	40.00
TOTAL	**100**	**100**

***Note*:** This table refers to the results of the pre and post-test regarding to fluency.

Fluency was measured when answering the questions in the test (part 2) and when describing the pictures (part 3). The findings illustrate that none of the students spoke fluent, showing no confidence and no flow in communication.

A 96.66 % had many hesitations and pauses when speaking. According to Blankenship and Kay (2015), hesitations are present when there is a lack of fluency of

speech and redundancy of the message, proper of beginner students. The 3.33% had several hesitations but were aimed to find the correct word or idea to be communicated.

At the end of the experiment, students had to do the post-test. According to table 2, there was a significant improvement when speaking of fluency with 51.66 % of students. Students presented few hesitations for reading a lecture on part 1, answering the questions of part 2, and describing the pictures of part 3 from the post-test; most of the time, students had to some seconds to order their ideas in their minds and afterward express them in a correct oral output.

Forty percent of students had gained confidence allowing them to flow in the conversation and communication. These improvements can be attributed to the use of mobile apps in the classroom that helps develop self-confidence when having to express ideas to other people and creating basic knowledge and management of the English language such as silences, pronunciation, rhythm or stress, adjustments, and mistakes (Haberl, 2018).

According to Yang (2013), students need to gain fluency. Therefore, teachers must design or adapt activities to help learners convey their messages. Ensuring that students are exposed to familiar content, vocabulary, and grammar structures allows students to perform faster. In addition, Samad et al. (2017) emphasize that students can have considerable progress on students' speaking development; the most effective, according to Samad, is Pod-cast.

Although most of the students had enhanced their fluency skills with the help of Tik Tok, Duolingo and Pod-cast, there still is an 8.33 % that have not made any improvement.

Table 13

Grammar results of pre and post-test

CRITERIA	PRE-TEST (%)	POST-TEST (%)
The speaker has frequent use of inappropriate verb tenses.	73.33	10

The speaker sometimes uses inappropriate verb tenses, and the speaker can correct grammar without prompts.	26.67	43.33
The speaker's output has few incorrect grammar use.	0	46.67
TOTAL	100	100

Note: This table refers to the results of the pre and post-test regarding to grammar.

Table 4 summarizes the results in the analysis of use of language. After the pre-test, none of the students had minor mistakes regarding grammar use. 73.33% of students had frequent use of inappropriate verb tenses, not being able to convey the message and 26.67% of students had regular use of improper verb tenses and grammar structures.

The use of language-grammar was imperative when describing the pictures and guided when answering the questions. It is clear that when one is asked a question, the question itself guides the type of tenses or structure needed to perform a task.

The low results can be attributed to the low level of knowledge. It is essential to realize that instructing language structure makes a difference with spoken dialect to consider target structures, students will likely procure and utilize them (Bahrani & Soltani, 2012). Teachers become aware of their students' limitations and help them correct and recognize their errors so they can be corrected.

After considering these concepts and using the apps, the results after the post-test generated a 46.67% of students that conveyed the message with just a few mistakes, 43.33% of students that sometimes used past incorrectly and only 10% that could not use the proper tense.

In addition, it is important to remember that in production, students tend to be nervous and takes time to lower the affective barriers and gain confidence.

(Nguyen, 2018) states that students' improvement can be attributed to the use of Apps. Some of these Apps have in their programation applied some grammar teaching

methods such as audio-lingual, communicative, and inductive approaches, which are essential when teaching grammar to students.

Sreena (2018) observes that several M-learning tools will help students develop their pronunciation, vocabulary, grammar, and fluency to have a correct oral output helping maintain a comprehensive conversation. Meanwhile, Retnawati et al. (2018, p.4) consider that a propper speaking skill can be developed using strategies such as “structure, system, method, technique, procedures, and process that a teacher uses during instruction”.

3.1.2 Which Appsare considered the most effective ones for improving speaking skills?

Table 14

Effectiveness of Mobile Apps

Mobile App	MEDIA	SD	OBSERVATION SHEET RESULTS							
			PRONUNCIATION		VOCABULARY		FLUENCY		GRAMMAR	
			TOTAL POINTS	(%)	TOTAL POINTS	(%)	TOTAL POINTS	(%)	TOTAL POINTS	(%)
Tik Tok	11.78	3.37	850	67,46	850	67,46	832	66,03	548	43.49
Duolingo	15.24	3.67	879	69,76	1008	80,00	526	41,75	392	31.11
Pod-Cast	11.22	4.02	856	67,94	860	68,25	422	33,49	610	48.41

Note: This table refers to the results of the observation sheets regarding the effectiveness of Mobile Apps.

After gathering the numerical data from the daily observation sheets from the classes for each application during the experiment. For each skill, students could have gained a total of 21 points daily, and at the end of the week the total points that could have been gained were 1260.

Duolingo has the highest media of the three applications used, with 15.24 compared to Tik Tok and Pod-cast. Additionally, Duolingo has 69.76 % of points in the most effective pronunciation and 80% for vocabulary.

These two results can be attributed to the fact that students are classified as millennials, and for them, it is entirely normal to use technology for their daily activities. Another factor that supports these two results can be that each student has a different learning style. In this case, the students are more Visual (Learns by seeing things), Musical, or Auditory (Learn by hearing, verbal instructions, read aloud) (Pashler, Harold et al., 2009). Duolingo offers a variety of tasks that include visuals, pronunciation, and listening activities, reaching all these learning styles.

Additionally, Duolingo was considered by the students as the most accessible App for learners to work with. Moreover, the complexity of activities fits the learner needs. The App starts with a pre-test that helps the learner start at a certain level and advance according to their abilities and results. These Apps grades the fluency, characters, and situations to capture the students' attention, increasing students' motivation by keeping them eager to enhance their speaking skills (Hafifah, 2021).

Regarding fluency, Duolingo had 41.75 % of points as the second helpful App. However, in contrast with pronunciation, this app was not considered adequate for grammar skills since it had the lowest scores from the three apps with 31.11% of points gained during the whole experiment.

Despite having the second-highest media with 11.78, Tik Tok had the lowest results from the three apps used during the intervention in pronunciation with 67.46 % of points, 67.46 % for vocabulary, and 43.49 % on grammar. However, this app is considered adequate for enhancing fluency skills since it had the highest score of the three apps used with 66.03% in the experiment. These results can be explained because Duolingo and Tik Tok focus on developing vocabulary and pronunciation rather than grammar.

Pod-cast had a media of 11.22, being the lowest form the three apps used for the intervention. In contrast with the media results, Pod-cast had the second-highest scores for pronunciation with 67.94 %, 68.25% for vocabulary. Regarding fluency, it has the lowest score of the three, with 33.49%. Oxkert (2018) states that the use of technology in the classroom encourages English learners to foster English-speaking success. While using

technology, they have access to complete new information and get immediate feedback, and both teachers and students acquire knowledge. Hafifah's study (2021) states that Duolingo is an effective App because it involves visual and audio aids, facilitating the students' pace of learning and engagement considering their learning style.

Table 15

Pronunciation improvement

Mobile Apps	Very hard to understand		Satisfactory; however, words sometimes have incorrect inflections		Accurate with correct inflections	
	Beginning (%)	End (%)	Beginning (%)	End (%)	Beginning (%)	End (%)
Tik Tok	95	8.3	5	71.7	0	20
Duolingo	21.7	3.3	78.3	70	0	26.7
Pod-Cast	16.7	18.3	80	70	3.3	11.6

Note: This table refers to the results of the observation sheets regarding pronunciation improvement.

Based on table 6, regarding pronunciation, Duolingo app reached 26.7% of accurate pronunciation; this information agrees with Teske (2017) that states that Duolingo is a complementary learning device for an oral English output through speaking inside the classroom. When Duolingo was used in the class during the experiment, and the students claimed to have difficulty understanding the pronunciation from the App, the teacher gave support by modeling the pronunciation, adapting speech rate, and articulating as many times as the students required. Based on Cavus's (2016) study that states that pronunciation is the key factor in expressing the right sound and stressing syllables. For these reasons, Duolingo has the lowest percentage of pronunciation problems with 3.3 % during the experiment.

Similarly, Tik Tok generated 71% at the end of the experiment in which students with satisfactory pronunciation, becoming the second most effective app that helps students improve their pronunciation. Students claimed that motivation and further engagement are the key while using the App. Similarly, the results of Duolingo and Pod-cast also had a positive effect on helping students improve their pronunciation so it can be understood while interacting orally with a 70% each. Since mobile apps motivate and help students realize the importance of communicating with native speakers, they provide more opportunities to hear the correct pronunciation and shadow it, comparing their pronunciation with the original Tik Tok (Azmi, 2017).

Table 16

Vocabulary Improvement

Mobile Apps	Very limited or incorrect words are often used		Vocabulary is moderate		Sufficient to be understood	
	Beginning (%)	End (%)	Beginning (%)	End (%)	Beginning (%)	End (%)
Tik Tok	75	17.1	25	34.6	0	48.3
Duolingo	13.3	21.2	38.3	1.7	3.3	48.4
Pod-Cast	40	16.0	60	46.7	0	37.3

Note: This table refers to the results of the observation sheets regarding vocabulary improvement.

According to table 7, regarding vocabulary, the results show that Duolingo helps students improve their vocabulary, starting from a 13.3% limited use of words. At the end of the fifth day, it increases to 48.4% of students having sufficient vocabulary words to be understood while speaking. The results of acquiring new vocabulary could be seen and tested when having conversations between students and the teacher during class time. Some of the activities involved showing students flashcards with a picture of a particular word seen previously in Duolingo so that the students associate it the words and meanings, in order for students to create well-structured sentences in their oral output. Using this type

of strategy helped students extended their vocabulary use and knowledge, vocabulary is one of the main factors that help learners reach English proficiency through listening, writing, reading, and speaking.

Ajisoko's (2020) study demonstrates that Duolingo is one of the best Mobile Apps to enhance vocabulary due to its simplicity of usage; it is friendly for children of all ages and adults, gives equal opportunities to all participants, innovates class, eliminating boredom during the learning process. Therefore, participants have excellent outcomes after using this app, a fact that was clarified in this study.

The second most useful app for acquiring vocabulary was Tik Tok with 48.3% in which students vocabulary for an oral output was well understood due to students had more time to shadow pronunciation and learn new words needed for them to create their own Tik Tok videos. As matter of fact, Muslem et al. (2017) emphasize that students' speaking skills regarding pronunciation are improved by using mobile apps to create video clips.

While 46.7 % of students that used Pod-cast improved moderately their vocabulary use, so they can transmit basic ideas or sentences when speaking or having a conversation.

Table 17

Fluency Improvement

Mobile Apps	The speaker has many hesitations		The speaker hesitates several times (%)		The speaker speaks confidently and naturally(%)	
	Beginning (%)	End (%)	Beginning (%)	End (%)	Beginning (%)	End (%)
Tik Tok	98.3	21.7	1.7	60	0	18.3
Duolingo	13,3	23.3	83.3	63.3	3.3	13.3
Pod-Cast	90	46.7	10	46.7	0	6.7

Note: This table refers to the results of the observation sheets regarding Fluencyy improvement.

Regarding fluency, table 8 shows the results show that Tik-Tok helps improve fluency. The results show that 98.3% of the speakers had many hesitations and great difficulty remembering words on the first day, while at the end of the experiment, 18.3% of the speakers spoke confidently and naturally without any distractions. This was evidenced through the videos created by students during the process.

As the experiment advanced, students increased the use of Tik Tok, and they gained more confidence to communicate. Speaking in public became a competitive challenge for students, supported by peer help, and increasing self-confidence.

With parents' permission, the best TikTokers were posted on the school's social media. Students were even more motivated to improve so that their videos also were published in social media.

These ideas were based on Muslem et al. (2017) who emphasize that students' speaking skills are improved by using mobile apps to create video clips where students can have peer support and immediate feedback from both peers and teachers. Additionally, students can shadow the pronunciation to improve their fluency at the moment of speaking.

Table 18

Grammar Improvement

Mobile Apps	The speaker makes frequent use of inappropriate verb tense or parts of speech (%)		The speaker occasionally uses an inappropriate verb tense or parts of speech (%)		The speaker speaks without incorrect grammar (%)	
	Beginning	End	Beginning	End	Beginning	End
Tik Tok	0	21.7	0	60	0	18.3
Duolingo	11.7	31	55	50	33.3	19
Pod-Cast	76.7	11.7	16.7	68.3	6.6	20

Note: This table refers to the results of the observation sheets regarding grammar improvement.

According to table 9, the App that improved grammar being the most effective was Pod-Cast—starting the first day with 11.7%; the most common mistakes were verb tense and sentence structure. At the end of the experiment, this App had the highest percentage of correct grammar use with a 20%, while 68.3 % of the students occasionally used inappropriate verb tense and incorrect uses parts of speech during a conversation.

The Podcast topics were chosen according to the students' familiarity and interest; they included movies, songs, information about their families and their occupations. Since they were familiar topics, they motivated the students to participate and maintain fluency while conveying the message.

Podcasts were chosen based on Sandoval Zapata's study (2020) that states that Pod-cast improves grammar due to the importance of accuracy when conveying the message rather than than the length of the message. Consequently, this technique will help the student avoid grammar mistakes or errors during the oral output when exposed to content and/or topic familiar to the students.

3.1.3 What are the students' perceptions of Tik Tok, Duolingo, and Pod-cast Applications to enhace students' speaking skills?

Table 10

Students Perception for the use of M-Apps

Criteria	Strongly Agree (%)	Agree (%)	Neutral (%)	Disagree (%)
MOTIVATION				
Motivated using Tik Tok inside and outside the classroom.	31.67	36.67	13.33	18.33
Motivated using Duolingo inside and outside the classroom.	56.67	28.33	6.67	8.33
Motivated using Pod-Cast inside and outside the classroom.	21.67	43.33	18.33	16.67

USE DIFFICULTIES				
Network problems during the use of Mobile Apps.	31.67	43.33	18.33	6.67
Time limitations when using Mobile Apps are not adequate.	56.67	28.33	6.67	8.3
ADVANTAGES FOR USE				
Mobile Apps increases learning flexibility.	40.00	33.33	15.00	11.67
Mobile Apps enhance their English-speaking skills.	38.33	41.67	13.33	6.67
Navigation through Mobile Apps is easy.	48.3	40.00	11.70	0.00

Note: This table refers to the results of the questionnaire regarding students' perception of the use of M-Apps.t

Based on table 10 above, the app that had the best acceptance was Duolingo with 56.67% of students strongly agreeing that they felt motivated to learn. Students had the opportunity to interact with each other and made Duolingo a social trend in the classroom. No one wanted to be excluded from the activities.

One of the reasons why Duolingo motivates students is that most students could access the app anytime and anywhere. In addition, Hafifah's (2021) study demonstrated that Duolingo is one of the most effective apps when learning a foreign language due to its easy installation on any technological device. The accessibility to the app is not difficult and offers constant feedback.

The second app that students felt motivated by is Tik Tok with 31.67%. For instance, this result can be attributed to the fact that this app is now a social trend in the world and that there is a variety of videos that can be seen throughout the world. The downside is that sometimes students felt challenged when choosing their outfit and image

when appearing in these videos. Nevertheless, the exposure was high, and their affective filters sometimes increased.

The app that least motivates students when fostering a second language was the use of Pod-cast with 21.67% since most students feel they need to demonstrate their speaking abilities perfectly when it refers to pronunciation, vocabulary, fluency, and grammar at the moment of having an oral output. This app is perceived as stricter and more academic.

In general, Aranego (2020) mentions that if Mobile-Apps are used correctly, they will become a communicative language approach that motivates and gives students the confidence to practice their speaking skills without stress and fear when producing their oral output.

The second criteria that refers to students' perceptions or opinions regarding the difficulties presented while using Tik Tok, Duolingo, and Pod-cast. A 56.67% strongly agreed that the significant difficulty presented when using mobile apps was the time limitation in the classroom. Sometimes, teachers do not provide students with time to practice with these apps because they feel pressure to complete the National Curriculum (2016) from the Ministry of Education of Ecuador for that specific school year and level. In addition, teachers must somehow accomplish five areas: Communication and Cultural Awareness, Oral Communication, Reading, Writing, and Language through the Arts. The majority of teachers give more importance to the four areas of the curriculum mentioned before and reducing the time for the Oral communication area practice so, teachers can be able to cover all the contents for their planning and requirements from the Ecuadorian Ministry of Education.

Thirty-one point sixty-seven percent strongly agree that network problems interfere with the use of Mobile Apps in the classroom. This network problem can be attributed since that in public high schools in Ecuador, few institutions have Wi-Fi installations due to the National public budget for Education is reduced and does not allowed for all high schools to have any kind of internet network. Another factor can be that since public high schools are

big and have lots of students, the wifi networks cannot reach the whole school. Besides, only 100 people can connect to certain internet modems simultaneously, and the connection becomes slow even then.

Although some students found difficulties, others had the perception that Mobile Apps have advantages when improving their speaking skills. For example, 48.33% consider that they are easy to navigate, 40% think that it allows learning flexibility, and 38.33% are motivated to enhance their English-speaking skills. Additionally, Chang (2017) states that Mobile Apps have flexibility because they can be used anywhere, any time needed, and many times the students require to produce knowledge in the Foreign language studied.

Conclusions

The findings of the present study strongly support the fact that Duolingo, TikTok, and Podcast applications functioned as teaching aids and communicative tools that increased students' speaking skills. All through the duration of this study, these apps behaved as speaking practice, authentic materials, collaborative projects, and adapted grammar exercises mobapps; Duolingo, TikTok, and Podcast remarkably sharpened oral skills. One significant aspect is how these apps assisted eighth graders to replicate correct pronunciation from native speakers and to have conversations using the target language making learners communicate successfully.

After using Tik Tok, Duolingo, and Podcast, students improved their oral communication skills according to the administration of pre-test, post-test and observation sheets for each speaking skill. In the first place, Duolingo became the most efficient app to develop pronunciation, vocabulary, fluency. Duolingo appealed to different learning styles and language needs, adapting the lessons to students' proficiency. Data reflected Duolingo was easily a vehicle to provide comprehensible input.

Using Duolingo, students corrected their pronunciation due to interactive charts because students tapped and learned new words. By posting videos on TikTok, students kept practicing target vocabulary and pronunciation. The data derived from post-test indicated there were less hesitations since learners had gained confidence. Being repeatedly exposed to vocabulary and structures, students spoke faster during their own videos. On the other hand, Podcast ranked the second app for pronunciation and helped students shadow articulation from the lessons.

TikTok aided with fluency when students had to make videos using target language, becoming the second helpful app for achieving fluency. Although it was not good for grammar, by posting Tiktok videos, students became confident, delivering correct speech. By using scaffolding activities, constant grammar and frequent vocabulary structures, eighth graders were able to speak faster and intelligibly.

Duolingo helped learners acquire target vocabulary easily because students were shown pictures and names, avoiding the need for translation. They were able to listen to target readings and answer comprehension questions. Conversely, Podcast was the second app for aiding students in building vocabulary growth. Data showed vocabulary was improved because students created better sentences.

One of the apps that helped students develop their grammar skills while having an oral output was Podcast; these results can be proven by the results obtained in the observation sheets. On the other hand, students reported learning grammar with Duolingo was easier, since they had instant feedback.

Motivation was key in order to lower students' affective filters and gain confidence when speaking in activities. Students agreed that Duolingo motivated them to learn. Tiktok was the second app for generating motivation. Students enjoyed having peer support and teacher feedback concerning their TikTok videos.

Finally, the students' feedback towards the use of the three apps was encouraging. Students considered the three mobapps to be user-friendly and easy to grasp. The majority of students were willing to use these three mobapps to enhance their English-speaking skills because they enriched their vocabulary, had meaningful exercises that made them understand better, and were a fun learning experience. Furthermore, students thought that these mobile apps provided them freedom and flexibility to choose the best schedule or time to learn outside the classroom, while inside the class, students learn at their own pace.

Recommendations

Based on the conclusions of this research, there are some recommendations for EFL teachers on the m-learning topic and mobapps. It is suggested teachers should complement face to face instruction with related target language podcasts and language apps. Students need to have extra access to authentic material and have better chances to understand and learn correct pronunciation from the beginning of an EFL course.

As suggested by Barlow et al. (2018) scaffolding must be included in all learning processes as a way of helping struggling learners. EFL teachers should provide different mobapps to teach different parts of the lesson and objectives so students can have different ways of acquiring target vocabulary and grammar and easily produce oral output.

Posting target language oriented videos on TikTok should be considered part of any English language program. As they have proved to be very effective for EFL learners, making it part of teacher activities is a must. Using social media is very beneficial for the school digital learning system. Bearing in mind that students need to be trained to be wary of all potential risks of being online and to follow closely the teacher's directions. Online behavior must be taught and considered in school politics and rules.

Based on the results of this study, school authorities must consider buying an EFL app subscription for all students, for example Duolingo, so all features can be unlocked and used throughout the school year. In addition, the use of these apps foster autonomous language practice and improve students' speaking skills as mentioned before. This is due to the fact that mobapps use different ways of imputing comprehensible language, meeting learner's needs, adjusting to their proficiency levels, and offering immediate feedback.

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Appendix

Appendix 1: students' pre and post-test



UNIVERSIDAD TÉCNICA PARTICULAR DE LOJA
La Universidad Católica de Loja
MODALIDAD A DISTANCIA
TITUALACION DE INGLÉS

Informative data: Please fill in the information below.

Gender:	Female	
	Male	
	8th grade EGB "B"	
City:		

ORAL PRE AND POST-TEST FOR STUDENTS

Pre-test ☐ Post-test ☐

QUESTIONS	TASK	PARAMETER TO EVALUATE
1	Read a text aloud	Pronunciation
2	Answer the question	vocabulary, grammar, Fluency, pronunciation.
3	Describe a picture	vocabulary, grammar, Fluency, Pronunciation.

Questions 1: Read a text aloud Directions: In this part of the test, you will read aloud the text on the sheet given. You will have 2 minutes to prepare. Then you will have 60 seconds to read the text aloud.

Rosie's family My family is not very big. I have one baby brother and no sisters. We live with our parents, my grandma, and our dog Flocky. My mother's name is Cecilia. She is short and a little fat with long hair. She works at a supermarket. My father's name is Carlos. He is a very funny and honest man. He works as a mechanic. My brother Carlos Jr. He is a big baby. He is sweet and playful.

Source: MINEDUC, https://recursos2.educacion.gob.ec/portfolio/sup_mod1_8vo_ingles/

Questions 2: Answer the three questions about the lecture above?

a) What are the names of the Rosie's family members?

b) What are the jobs of Rosie's parents?

c) How is the character of Rosie's father?

Question 3: Describe a picture Directions: In this part of the test, you will describe the picture on your screen in as much detail as you can. You will have 80 seconds to prepare your response. Then you will have 60 seconds to speak about the picture.



Criteria	Points
Fluency 5. The speaker speaks confidently, and the conversation flows smoothly. 3. The speaker hesitates several times, needing time to think about using some words a bit. 1. The speaker has many hesitations.	
Pronunciation 5. Is accurate with correct inflections. 3. Pronunciation is satisfactory; however, words have incorrect inflections. 1. Pronunciation is very hard to understand.	
Grammar 5. The speaker's output has a few incorrect grammar use. 3. The speaker sometimes uses inappropriate verb tenses, and the speaker can correct grammar without prompts. 1. The speaker makes frequent use of inappropriate verb tenses.	
Vocabulary 5. Vocabulary is sufficient to be understood in a different context. 3. Vocabulary is moderate; sometimes speaker needs guidance. 1. Vocabulary is very limited.	
Total	

Adapted from: *Marek, M. W., & Wu, W. (2011, May 14). Using Facebook and SKYPE as Social Media in an EFL conversation class. Paper presented at the 28th International Conference on Teaching and Learning in the ROC, National Taichung University of Education, Taichung, Taiwan.*

Appendix 2: Students' Perception Questionnarie Applied at the End of Experiment



UNIVERSIDAD TÉCNICA PARTICULAR DE LOJA
La Universidad Católica de Loja
MODALIDAD A DISTANCIA
TITUALACION DE INGLÉS

Apreciado estudiante,

El objetivo de este cuestionario es obtener información con relación al uso de las aplicaciones móviles como Tik Tok, Pod-Cast, y Duolingo para mejorar la habilidad del habla en la enseñanza del inglés como lengua extranjera. Esta información será utilizada con propósitos académicos y de investigación. Por favor contestar de manera sincera y objetiva para garantizar los resultados.

Choose the answer according to your perception's

1. Mobile apps play an important role in the speaking process in the classroom. (LAS APLICACIONES MOBILES JUEGAN UN PAPEL IMPORTANTE EN EL PROCESO DEL DESARROLLO DEL HABLA DE INGLES EN EL AULA)

- Strongly agree (totalmente de acuerdo
- Agree (de acuerdo)
- Neutral (neutral)
- Disagree (desacuerdo)

2. Mobile Apps improve communication among teachers and students inside the classroom. (LAS APLICACIONES MOVILES AYUDAN A MEJORAR LA COMUNICACION ENTRE EL ALUMNO Y DOCENTE EN EL AULA)

- Strongly agree (totalmente de acuerdo
- Agree (de acuerdo)

- Neutral (neutral)
- Disagree (desacuerdo)

3. Mobile Learning increases the flexibility of learning. (APRENDER USANDO EL CELULAR AUMENTA EL APRENDIZAJE FLEXIBLE)

- Strongly agree (totalmente de acuerdo
- Agree (de acuerdo)
- Neutral (neutral)
- Disagree (desacuerdo)

4. Mobile devices can help improve learning with adequate teachers' support. (APRENDER CON APARATOS MOBILES AYUDAN A APRENDER CON LA AYUDA DE LOS DOCENTES)

- Strongly agree (totalmente de acuerdo
- Agree (de acuerdo)
- Neutral (neutral)
- Disagree (desacuerdo)

5. The use of Tik Tok inside and outside the classroom allows students to interact orally with each other making them feel motivated. (EL USO DEL TIK TOK DENTRO Y FUERA DEL AULA PERMITE QUE EL ESTUDIANTE INTERACTUE DE UNA MANERA ORAL LOGRANDO QUE SE SIENTA MAS MOTIVADO)

- Strongly agree (totalmente de acuerdo
- Agree (de acuerdo)
- Neutral (neutral)
- Disagree (desacuerdo)

6. The use of Pod-Cast inside and outside the classroom allows students to interact orally with each other making them feel motivated. (EL USO DEL POD CAST DENTRO Y FUERA DEL AULA PERMITE QUE EL ESTUDIANTE INTERACTUE DE UNA MANERA ORAL LOGRANDO QUE SE SIENTA MAS MOTIVADO)

- Strongly agree (totalmente de acuerdo

- Agree (de acuerdo)
- Neutral (neutral)
- Disagree (desacuerdo)

7. The use of Duolingo inside and outside the classroom allows students to interact orally with each other making them feel motivated. (EL USO DEL DUOLINGO DENTRO Y FUERA DEL AULA PERMITE QUE EL ESTUDIANTE INTERACTUE DE UNA MANERA ORAL LOGRANDO QUE SE SIENTA MAS MOTIVADO)

- Strongly agree (totalmente de acuerdo
- Agree (de acuerdo)
- Neutral (neutral)
- Disagree (desacuerdo)

8. Navigation through Mobile learning is easy (EL USO DEL CELUAR ES FACIL).

- Strongly agree (totalmente de acuerdo
- Agree (de acuerdo)
- Neutral (neutral)
- Disagree (desacuerdo)

9. The use of Tik-Tok increases my English Vocabulary (EL USO DEL TIK-TOK INCREMENTA MI VOCABULARIO EN INGLES)

- Strongly agree (totalmente de acuerdo
- Agree (de acuerdo)
- Neutral (neutral)
- Disagree (desacuerdo)

10. The use of Tik-Tok has correctly improved pronunciation of words in English (EL USO DEL TIK TOK HA AYUDADO A MEJORAR MI PRONUNCIACION EN INGLES)

- Strongly agree (totalmente de acuerdo
- Agree (de acuerdo)
- Neutral (neutral)
- Disagree (desacuerdo)

11. The use of Tik-Tok has improved my Grammar when speaking English (EL USO DEL TIK TOK HA MEJORADO MI GRAMATICA EN INGLES)

- Strongly agree (totalmente de acuerdo
- Agree (de acuerdo)
- Neutral (neutral)
- Disagree (desacuerdo)

12. The use of Tik-Tok has improved your Fluency when speaking English. (ELUSO DEL TIK TOK HA MEJORADO MI FLUIDEZ AL HABLAR INGLES)

- Strongly agree (totalmente de acuerdo
- Agree (de acuerdo)
- Neutral (neutral)
- Disagree (desacuerdo)

13. The use of Pod-Cast increases my English Vocabulary (EL USO DEL Pod-cast INCREMENTA MI VOCABULARIO EN INGLES)

- Strongly agree (totalmente de acuerdo
- Agree (de acuerdo)
- Neutral (neutral)
- Disagree (desacuerdo)

14. The use of Pod-Cast has improved correctly pronunciation of words in English (EL USO DEL POD-CAST HA AYUDADO A MEJORAR MI PRONUNCIACION EN INGLES)

- Strongly agree (totalmente de acuerdo
- Agree (de acuerdo)
- Neutral (neutral)
- Disagree (desacuerdo)

15. The use of Pod-cast has improved correctly grammar of words in English (EL USO DEL POD-CAST HA AYUDADO A MEJORAR MI GRAMATICA EN INGLES)

- Strongly agree (totalmente de acuerdo
- Agree (de acuerdo)

- Neutral (neutral)
- Disagree (desacuerdo)

16. The use of Pod-cast has improved your Fluency when speaking English. (EL USO DEL POD-CAST HA MEJORADO MI FLUIDEZ AL HABLAR INGLES)

- Strongly agree (totalmente de acuerdo
- Agree (de acuerdo)
- Neutral (neutral)
- Disagree (desacuerdo)

17. The use of Duolingo increases my English vocabulary (EL USO DUOLINGO INCREMENTA MI VOCABULARIO EN INGLES)

- Strongly agree (totalmente de acuerdo
- Agree (de acuerdo)
- Neutral (neutral)
- Disagree (desacuerdo)

18. The use of Duolingo has improved correctly pronunciation of words in English (EL USO DEL DUOLINGO HA AYUDADO A MEJORAR MI PRONUNCIACION EN INGLES)

- Strongly agree (totalmente de acuerdo
- Agree (de acuerdo)
- Neutral (neutral)
- Disagree (desacuerdo)

19. The use of DUOLINGO has improved correctly gramar of words in English (EL USO DEL DUOLINGO HA AYUDADO A MEJORAR MI GRAMATICA EN INGLES)

- Strongly agree (totalmente de acuerdo
- Agree (de acuerdo)
- Neutral (neutral)
- Disagree (desacuerdo)

20. The use of Duolingo has improved your Fluency when speaking English. (EL USO DEL DUOLINGO HA MEJORADO MI FLUIDEZ AL HABLAR INGLES)

- Strongly agree (totalmente de acuerdo
- Agree (de acuerdo)
- Neutral (neutral)
- Disagree (desacuerdo)

21. I want for my English teachers to use Mobile Apps when teaching in classrooms English speaking skills (YO QUIERO QUE MIS DOCENTES DE INGLES USEN LAS APPS PARA LAS ENSEÑARAR INGLES**)**

- Strongly agree (totalmente de acuerdo
- Agree (de acuerdo)
- Neutral (neutral)
- Disagree (desacuerdo)

22. The use of Tik Tok has been effective at the moment in improving my speaking skill. (EL USO DEL TIK TOK HA SIDO EFECTIVO AL MOMENTO DE HABLAR DE INGLES)

- Strongly agree (totalmente de acuerdo
- Agree (de acuerdo)
- Neutral (neutral)
- Disagree (desacuerdo)

23. The use of Podcast has been effective at the moment in improving my speaking skill. (EL USO DEL POD-CAST HA SIDO EFECTIVO AL MOMENTO DE MEJORAR MI HABLA)

- Strongly agree (totalmente de acuerdo
- Agree (de acuerdo)
- Neutral (neutral)
- Disagree (desacuerdo)

24. The use of Duolingo has been effective at the moment in improving my speaking skill.(EL USO DEL DUOLINGO HA SIDO EFECTIVO AL MOMENTO DE HABLAR EN INGLES)

- Strongly agree (totalmente de acuerdo
- Agree (de acuerdo)
- Neutral (neutral)
- Disagree (desacuerdo)

25. There has been internet interference at the moment of the using Mobile Apps in the classrooms.(LA ITERFERENCIA DEL INTERNET HA SIDO UN OBSTACULO AL USAR LAS APPS EN EL AULA)

- Strongly agree (totalmente de acuerdo
- Agree (de acuerdo)
- Neutral (neutral)
- Disagree (desacuerdo)

26. The time limitation when using Mobile Apps are appropriate to develop English speaking skills. (EL TIEMPO HA SIDO UNA RESTRINCCION PARA EL USO DE APLICACIONES PARA DESARRROLLAR LA DESTREZA)

- Strongly agree (totalmente de acuerdo
- Agree (de acuerdo)
- Neutral (neutral)
- Disagree (desacuerdo)

Appendix 3: Teachers' Observation Sheet for Class Activities



UNIVERSIDAD TÉCNICA PARTICULAR DE LOJA
La Universidad Católica de Loja
MODALIDAD A DISTANCIA
TITUALACION DE INGLÉS

OBSERVATION SHEET

Class :

Nº	CODE	ASPECT SCORE OF SPEAKING				
		PRONUNCIATON	VOCABULARY	FLUENCY	GRAMMAR	SCORE

Field Notes:

Rubric of Scoring System

PRONUNCIATON	VOCABULARY	FLUENCY	GRAMMAR
5. Pronunciation is accurate	5. Vocabulary is sufficient	5. The speaker speaks confidently, and conversation flows smoothly.	5. The speaker's output has a few incorrect grammar use.
3. Pronunciation is satisfactory	3. Vocabulary is moderate (some problems)	3. The speaker hesitates several times (needing to thinking words)	3. The speaker occasionally has mistakes.
1. Pronunciation is very hard to understand	1. Vocabulary is very limited	1. The speaker has many hesitations.	1. The speaker makes frequent use of inappropriate verb tense.

Appendix 4: Class planning



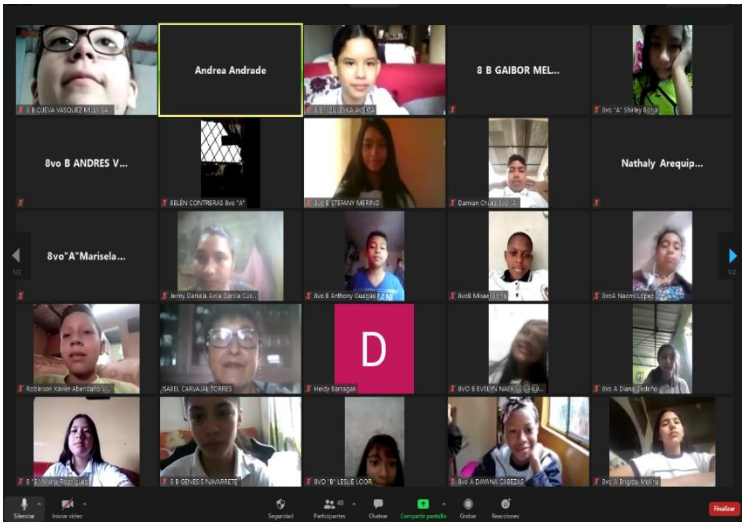
UNIVERSIDAD TÉCNICA PARTICULAR DE LOJA
La Universidad Católica de Loja
MODALIDAD A DISTANCIA
TITUALACION DE INGLÉS

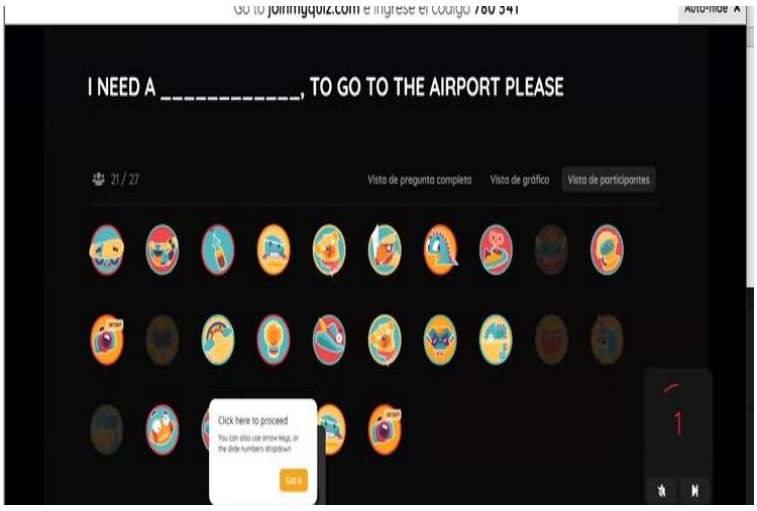
Session (1)		
Date: 17 MAY 2021	**Length:** 35 min	**App:** Tick Tock
TOPIC: Greetings	**Language Skill**: Vocabulary, Grammar	
LEARNING OBJECTIVE 1: Students learn how to solve problems of daily life related to social, it is necessary to apply logical, creative, critical, complex reasoning strategies, and communicate our ideas in an assertive way to act with autonomy and independence.		
Skill and performance criteria: Understand phrases and expressions related to areas of most immediate priority within the personal and educational domains, provided speech is clearly and slowly articulated. (Example: daily life, free time, school activities, etc.) Understand most changes in the topic of discussion if people speak slowly.		

TIME	**ACTIVITY**
10	General indications of the mechanics of the class
15	Give a general review about greetings with the help of power point slides.
5	Ask students (S's) to repeat the pronunciation of greetings taught

<table>
<tr><td>10</td><td colspan="2">Explain the homework, where S’s with the help of Tik Tok they have to pronounce the greetings shown at class</td></tr>
<tr><td colspan="2">MATERIALS</td><td>ASSESSMENT</td></tr>
<tr><td colspan="2" rowspan="2">ZOOM
POWER POINT SLIDES</td><td>PRONUNCIATION
TIK TOK APP</td></tr>
<tr><td>HOMEWORK
TIK TOK: Create a Tik Tok explain greetings in English.</td></tr>
</table>

Appendix 5: Students' participation through Zoom Meetings





Appendix 6: Students' Summary of points gained for Pronunciation

SUMMARY OF FINAL POINTS OF APPS USED TO IMPROVED PRONUNCIATION

Grade: Eight grade

Year: 2021

Nº	STUDENTS' CODE	ASPECT SCORE OF SPEAKING			SCORE
		TIK TOK	DUOLINGO	PODCAST	
1	A1	13	17	15	45
2	A2	21	23	17	61
3	A3	13	15	13	41
4	A4	19	21	25	65
5	A5	15	15	15	45
6	A6	17	13	15	45
7	A7	15	15	13	43
8	A8	13	15	15	43
9	A9	15	17	11	43
10	A10	15	17	15	47
11	A11	15	13	15	43

12	A12	13	13	15	41
13	A13	15	13	15	43
14	A14	21	23	25	69
15	A15	13	13	15	41
16	A16	15	13	15	43
17	A17	15	15	13	43
18	A18	15	13	13	41
19	A19	15	13	15	43
20	A20	13	15	13	41
21	A21	13	13	13	39
22	A22	13	13	13	39
23	A23	15	15	13	43
24	A24	13	15	15	43
25	A25	15	13	13	41
26	A26	13	13	13	39
27	A27	13	15	15	43
28	A28	13	17	15	45
29	A29	15	15	15	45
30	A30	13	15	13	41
31	A31	15	17	15	47
32	A32	15	17	13	45
33	A33	15	17	15	47
34	A34	15	13	15	43

35	A35	13	15	15	43
36	A36	11	11	13	35
37	A37	13	15	13	41
38	A38	13	13	15	41
39	A39	15	13	15	43
40	A40	13	15	13	41
41	A41	15	13	13	41
42	A42	13	13	11	37
43	A43	15	13	15	43
44	A44	15	15	13	43
45	A45	13	15	15	43
46	A46	13	13	15	41
47	A47	15	13	13	41
48	A48	15	13	15	43
49	A49	15	15	13	43
50	A50	15	13	15	43
51	A51	13	15	13	41
52	A52	15	13	13	41
53	A53	13	15	15	43
54	A54	13	15	13	41
55	A55	13	13	15	41
56	A56	11	15	15	41
57	A57	13	15	13	41

58	A58	13	15	13	41
59	A59	11	13	15	39
60	A60	13	15	13	41

Appendix 7: Students' Summary of points gained for Vocabulary

SUMMARY OF FINAL POINTS OF APPS USED TO IMPROVED VOCABULARY

Grade: 8th l grade
Year: 2021

Nº	STUDENTS' CODE	ASPECT SCORE OF SPEAKING			SCORE
		TIK TOK	DUOLINGO	PODCAST	
1	A1	15	13	13	41
2	A2	19	25	15	59
3	A3	13	13	13	39
4	A4	19	25	17	61
5	A5	15	17	13	45
6	A6	15	17	13	45
7	A7	15	17	15	47
8	A8	15	15	13	43
9	A9	15	17	15	47
10	A10	13	19	15	47
11	A11	15	15	13	43
12	A12	15	19	13	47

13	A13	13	19	13	45
14	A14	19	25	17	61
15	A15	13	19	13	45
16	A16	15	17	15	47
17	A17	13	19	15	47
18	A18	13	11	15	39
19	A19	13	11	15	39
20	A20	13	13	13	39
21	A21	13	19	15	47
22	A22	13	15	13	41
23	A23	15	19	15	49
24	A24	13	19	15	47
25	A25	15	19	15	49
26	A26	13	19	15	47
27	A27	13	17	15	45
28	A28	15	19	13	47
29	A29	15	17	15	47
30	A30	13	19	15	47
31	A31	13	19	15	47
32	A32	15	19	15	49
33	A33	15	19	13	47
34	A34	15	19	15	49
35	A35	13	17	15	45

36	A36	13	17	13	43
37	A37	15	19	13	47
38	A38	15	17	15	47
39	A39	15	19	13	47
40	A40	13	15	15	43
41	A41	15	17	13	45
42	A42	13	15	15	43
43	A43	15	17	15	47
44	A44	15	17	13	45
45	A45	13	17	13	43
46	A46	13	15	15	43
47	A47	15	15	13	43
48	A48	13	15	15	43
49	A49	13	17	13	43
50	A50	13	15	15	43
51	A51	13	13	15	41
52	A52	15	15	15	45
53	A53	13	13	15	41
54	A54	13	17	13	43
55	A55	13	17	15	45
56	A56	13	17	15	45
57	A57	15	15	15	45
58	A58	13	17	15	45

59	A59	15	15	15	45
60	A60	13	13	15	41

Appendix 8: Students' Summary of points gained for Fluency

SUMMARY OF FINAL POINTS OF APPS USED TO IMPROVE FLUENCY

Grade: Eight grade

Year: 2021

Nº	STUDENTS' CODE	ASPECT SCORE OF SPEAKING			SCORE
		TIK TOK	DUOLINGO	PODCAST	
1	A1	5	15	7	27
2	A2	17	15	17	49
3	A3	11	15	5	31
4	A4	15	25	17	57
5	A5	5	15	7	27
6	A6	5	15	11	31
7	A7	11	9	5	25
8	A8	11	15	7	33
9	A9	11	11	5	27
10	A10	5	15	7	27
11	A11	7	15	7	29
12	A12	11	15	7	33
13	A13	5	9	5	19

14	A14	17	25	17	59
15	A15	11	15	7	33
16	A16	7	21	5	33
17	A17	11	15	7	33
18	A18	11	11	5	27
19	A19	11	15	7	33
20	A20	5	11	5	21
21	A21	11	9	5	25
22	A22	5	9	5	19
23	A23	11	15	5	31
24	A24	11	15	11	37
25	A25	11	15	7	33
26	A26	7	15	7	29
27	A27	11	15	7	33
28	A28	11	15	9	35
29	A29	5	15	7	27
30	A30	11	15	7	33
31	A31	11	21	11	43
32	A32	5	11	5	21
33	A33	11	15	7	33
34	A34	11	15	7	33
35	A35	11	15	7	33
36	A36	5	15	5	25

37	A37	5	9	5	19
38	A38	5	15	7	27
39	A39	5	15	5	25
40	A40	5	11	5	21
41	A41	11	21	5	37
42	A42	11	11	5	27
43	A43	11	9	11	31
44	A44	11	15	5	31
45	A45	5	9	5	19
46	A46	5	15	5	25
47	A47	11	9	5	25
48	A48	11	9	5	25
49	A49	5	9	5	19
50	A50	5	15	7	27
51	A51	5	9	5	19
52	A52	11	17	7	35
53	A53	11	15	11	37
54	A54	5	9	5	19
55	A55	5	15	7	27
56	A56	11	21	7	39
57	A57	11	17	5	33
58	A58	11	9	11	31
59	A59	5	15	7	27

60	A60	5	9	5	19

Appendix 9: Students' Summary of points gained for Grammar

SUMMARY OF FINAL POINTS OF APPS USED TO IMPROVE GRAMMAR

Grade: Eight grade

Year: 2021

Nº	STUDENTS' CODE	ASPECT SCORE OF SPEAKING			SCORE
		TIK TOK	DUOLINGO	PODCAST	
1	A1	11	13	6	30
2	A2	19	19	8	46
3	A3	13	9	6	28
4	A4	19	19	8	46
5	A5	11	9	6	26
6	A6	11	11	8	30
7	A7	11	9	6	26
8	A8	11	11	8	30
9	A9	11	7	6	24

10	A10	11	9	10	30
11	A11	7	11	8	26
12	A12	9	9	8	26
13	A13	7	7	6	20
14	A14	17	19	8	44
15	A15	11	7	8	26
16	A16	9	7	8	24
17	A17	11	7	8	26
18	A18	9	9	6	24
19	A19	7	7	6	20
20	A20	11	9	6	26
21	A21	11	7	6	24
22	A22	7	11	6	24
23	A23	9	9	6	24
24	A24	9	11	4	24
25	A25	9	7	6	22
26	A26	11	7	4	22
27	A27	9	7	4	20
28	A28	11	7	6	24
29	A29	9	11	4	24
30	A30	9	7	8	24
31	A31	11	11	6	28
32	A32	7	7	8	22

33	A33	11	7	8	26
34	A34	11	7	8	26
35	A35	9	9	6	24
36	A36	9	7	4	20
37	A37	11	9	4	24
38	A38	9	7	6	22
39	A39	11	7	6	24
40	A40	7	9	4	20
41	A41	7	11	6	24
42	A42	11	7	6	24
43	A43	9	11	6	26
44	A44	7	11	6	24
45	A45	11	9	8	28
46	A46	7	11	2	20
47	A47	11	7	6	24
48	A48	7	7	6	20
49	A49	11	7	6	24
50	A50	7	11	8	26
51	A51	7	7	2	16
52	A52	11	7	8	26
53	A53	11	7	6	24
54	A54	7	9	2	18
55	A55	11	7	8	26

56	A56	11	11	8	30
57	A57	11	7	6	24
58	A58	9	11	6	26
59	A59	11	11	6	28
60	A60	7	7	6	20

Appendix 10: Letter for Permission

Loja, mayo de 2021

Sr/Sra.
Recto/Director
Presente.

De mi consideración:

Reciba un cordial saludo desde la Universidad Técnica Particular de Loja –UTPL y desde la Coordinación Académica del Programa de Maestría en Pedagogía de los Idiomas Nacionales y Extranjeros mención enseñanza de inglés, a la vez que le deseo éxitos en sus importantes funciones.

Durante varias décadas la UTPL viene ofreciendo la formación de docentes en el área de inglés, quienes necesitan involucrarse en diferentes actividades de investigación que les permite conocer la realidad educativa de nuestro país y de esta manera contribuir con alternativas de mejoramiento a la enseñanza-aprendizaje del Inglés. Para ello, como metodología de enseñanza aprendizaje, se desarrollan actividades que integran la teoría, la práctica y la investigación los cuales permiten que el estudiante pueda desarrollar las competencias necesarias para poder desempeñarse profesionalmente de manera creativa e innovadora.

Por este motivo, solicito su permiso para que los maestrantes, que actualmente cursan el módulo en el cual desarrollan la tesis, puedan aplicar los instrumentos de recolección de datos que consiste en encuesta a docentes y estudiantes, entrevista a los docentes y observación de clases. *Esta investigación tendrá un impacto positivo en el mejoramiento del proceso de enseñanza aprendizaje del idioma inglés.*

Agradezco su valiosa colaboración y le expreso mis sentimientos de especial consideración.

Atentamente,

Mgtr. Gina Karina Camacho Minuche
DIRECTORA DEL PROGRAMA DE MAESTRIA